school authorities didn't want her to see that boys had been admitted in the convent. Although we realized there was no other option but to leave, it was difficult to overcome the feeling of being ditched so brazenly by the nuns. I had to join Model Academy, which was situated in the heart of the town, and finished my matriculation from there in 1960. Though it was a Hindi-medium school till the middle section, the standard of education was very good, and the teachers were very sincere and committed. I still remember the principal, Harbans Lal Gupta, and his wife, Shanta, as both of them took the classes for the tenth standard. I secured 8th position in J&K University in the matriculation examination.

During this period, Major General S.H.F.J. (Sam) Manekshaw was the commanding general (GOC) of 26 Infantry Division in Jammu. Flamboyant and dashing, he was one of the primary motivating factors in my decision to join the army. A story doing the rounds at that time was that one evening, while Sam Manekshaw was taking a stroll on the road leading to the officers' transit camp, he came across a young officer returning from leave, and struggling with his luggage. On finding him in a spot, the general, then in his 'civvies' (civilian clothes), promptly helped the officer carry his bags to the transit camp. The guards on duty smartly saluted their GOC. A bit perplexed, the young officer guardedly enquired of him, 'thank you, sir … but might I know who you are?'

Sam replied, 'Oh, I help soldiers like I just did, and in my spare time I command the division!'

In 1959, even though dad was posted to Udhampur, we continued to stay on in Jammu. In those days, there used to be no accommodation other than a 'basha' (an innovation of the Indian Army, this was a temporary structure made of mud and stone with a thatched roof) or a tent at Udhampur, and almost everyone lived in 'bashas' or under canvas. It was quite an experience to have a huge tent known as 'English Pattern Indian Police' (EPIP) for a house, whenever we went there for a holiday from Jammu. At night we were often woken up by huge bandicoots scurrying all over, foraging for something to nibble at, including our toes or nose.